

Business Headache: Selling to non-buyers

The goal of this paper is to offer a simple framework that can be applied to an idea before investing months into it. Potentially this approach can help in saving time and budget. Founders frequently confuse the existence of a problem with the existence of a sufficiently strong, accessible, monetizable demand for a particular solution.

Before building a business around an idea, determine whether you are capturing existing demand or taking on the much harder task of creating demand.

Most even a bit educated founders start with "how do I sell my product?" But, we should instead ask "am I trying to sell to buyers or to non-buyers?" or "am I approaching someone who already has a reason to say yes, or am I trying to create the reason?"

The question isn't whether you can convince someone to buy. The question is whether enough people already have a reason to buy.

The existence of a problem is not the same thing as the existence of demand for a solution. If there is no demand then we must question if we even want to get into something that require awareness creation, customer education etc., meaning a lot of time, money and nerves with an uncertain result.

If you have limited resources (time and money) and are looking for a relatively predictable path to revenue, prefer markets where demand is already observable rather than markets where demand must first be created.

Don't accidentally enter a demand-creation business when you think you're entering a straightforward sales business.

Time is money → Ask the right questions immediately

Spending months on an idea that doesn't sell isn't just time lost, but also potential money lost that we could make on the other place. Obviously, we don't know instantly whether it sell or not, so we must put it through a process.

Important questions to ask when assessing an idea, with their proper order:

1. Do customers already recognize the problem?
2. Are they actively looking for a way to solve it?
3. Are they already spending money on it?
4. If their current solution disappeared tomorrow, would the customer actively look for another provider?

If the answer is no at each step, you're educating rather than selling, and that's usually a sign to stop. Sooner rather than later. You're doing awareness, not sales.

Let's demonstrate this framework with a small thought experiment:

We have an idea. First, let's ask a question like, "does the customers already recognize they have a problem?"

If no, recognize that you are not capturing existing demand. You are now taking on the additional task of creating demand. Without any indications that the customers are aware of their problem, we are not able to sell them. We must create awareness first, and that's a too large job for small players.

If yes, are they already searching for solutions?

If no, again, stop! You're educating before selling.

If yes, are they already spending money on it?

If no, stop. You might be trying to create a budget that doesn't exist.

If yes, then check if there's evidence they'd actually switch providers.

If not, be cautious. Customers may be locked into existing solutions.

We can add one more criterion. If we disappeared tomorrow, would the customers actively look for another provider? If yes, we're solving a real problem. If no, our product may be seen as optional rather than essential.

Am I approaching someone who already has a reason to say yes, or am I trying to create the reason?

Based on the previous questions discussed, we could create a spectrum with a Demand Recognition / Readiness Score like:

- No recognized problem → 0
- Recognized problem → 1
- Actively searching → 2
- Already spending → 3
- Actively evaluating alternatives → 4
- Ready to switch/buy → 5

The higher the score, the more likely you are to be capturing existing demand rather than creating it. The score does not determine whether an idea is good or bad. It indicates how much demand creation may be required before selling can become predictable.

After this assessment, the right question to ask isn't "How to sell" but rather "**Where on this spectrum am I trying to sell?**" Neither point is inherently bad. But they're **completely different businesses**, requiring different amounts of time, money, education, and patience.

If you are a small business or a solopreneur and you have limited resources, and you don't plan to lose a year on validating a business idea, trying to sell to targets who has no recognized need for your offer is super high risk and time consuming without a likely benefit. Maybe you are lucky, but think twice.

Recognized buyers vs Latent non-buyers

Let's map out precisely based on what we have previously explained how can we make a difference between recognized buyers (potentially good targets) and latent non-buyers (very bad targets).

Recognized buyers	Latent non-buyers
Already recognize they have a problem	Don't perceive the problem as a problem
Actively search for solutions	Usually don't search for a solution
Understand why the problem matters	Need to be educated before they understand the value
Already spend money to solve it	Have little or no budget allocated to it
Compare providers, prices, and solutions	Often respond with "thanks" rather than buying
Can understand a service offer immediately	You have to explain <i>why they need the service</i> first
You are competing for existing demand	You are trying to create demand
Sales can start with "Here is how I can solve your problem"	Sales starts with "Let me convince you that you have a problem"
A small number of conversations can produce buyers	You may need a very large number of conversations to find an anomaly
Strong environment for testing an offer	High-risk environment for interpreting even minor positive signals

Small businesses and startups are particularly vulnerable to choosing latent non-buyers without realizing they're choosing latent non-buyers. The decreasing cost of creating products makes it easier to spend months building things that are difficult to sell.

Before optimizing the selling process, determine whether you are operating in an environment where customers already exhibit buying intent.

Possible Sale $\neq$ Viable Market (The One-Sale Trap)

Someone buying from you once proves that an offer is *sellable*. It does not prove that a *market is viable*.

A single sale proves:

"Someone can be convinced to buy this."

It does not prove:

"There are enough people who want this badly enough, and frequently enough, to sustain a business."

Interpreting a single, isolated sale as evidence of a broader market is a classic validation trap.

- **Incorrect Interpretation:** 1 sale $\rightarrow$ evidence of a market
- **Correct Interpretation:** 1 sale $\rightarrow$ evidence that the offer is not impossible to sell

Mistaking this weak signal for market validation leads founders to spend months hunting unsuccessfully for a second customer. The sale wasn't fake, but the interpretation was wrong.

To establish market demand, you need repeated, independent buying behavior. One customer is an anomaly; multiple customers independently buying for the same reason evidence a real market.

The central question is never: *"Can I get someone to pay?"*

It is always: *"Can I repeatedly find people who already want this badly enough to pay for it?"*

One sale proves possibility. Repeated, independent sales provide evidence of demand.